

THE CROONERS (From far left) Beth Hart, Samantha Fish, Vanessa Collier, (inset) Dana Fuchs; Sheryl Youngblood (below)

MUSIC

SHE'S GOT THE BLUES

There's an all-female line-up at the **Mahindra Blues Festival** this year

This year, for the first time, the Mahindra Blues Festival—taking place at Mehboob Studios in Mumbai on February 10 and 11—will have an all-female line-up. Singer Tipriti Kharbangar, who has played the event more than any other act as part of the duo Soulmate, will open the proceedings with her new band Mama Tips and the Mama's Bois. Here's a brief introduction to the five international female artists—each of whom is from the US—performing live this weekend:

BETH HART

Grammy-nominated singer/songwriter and multi-instrumentalist Beth Hart, who has a worldwide following, headlined in 2019. Since then, she's released a record of Led Zeppelin covers, so we can expect to hear some of that group's hits as well as songs from her upcoming album, *Broken*. Hart, who has openly shared her struggles with mental illness, is likely to deliver another emotionally-charged and vocally virtuosic set.

DANA FUCHS

Vocalist Dana Fuchs, who first played the festival in 2013, graduates from supporting act to headliner. She returns with three studio albums' worth of material that she's released after that last appearance. With a voice that recalls Janis Joplin and a troubled past marred by family tragedies, Fuchs—whose surname is pronounced 'Fyooks'—is the kind of artist whose blues is infused with a lot of rock and soul.

SAMANTHA FISH

Among the hottest new acts in the blues world, guitarist/ singer Samantha Fish boasts five No.1s on the US Billboard Blues Albums chart: 2015's *Wild Heart*, 2017's *Belle of the West*, 2019's *Kill Or Be Kind*, 2021's *Faster* and 2023's *Death Wish Blues*. Fish, who is renowned for her impressive guitar-playing, blends the blues with rock, country and funk.

SHERYL YOUNGBLOOD

An exponent of the Chicago Blues style, singer/ songwriter and multi-instrumentalist Sheryl Youngblood has opened for Buddy Guy at his club Legends in Chicago and played the offshoot Mahindra Blues Weekend festival at that venue in 2023. In addition to her own compositions, which bear strong influences from gospel and soul, she's bound to croon some Koko Taylor whose tunes she's covered at tribute shows.

VANESSA COLLIER

With wins in the Contemporary Blues Female Artist and Blues Instrumentalist – Horns categories at the Blues Music Awards almost every year since 2017, saxophonist/singer Vanessa Collier is acclaimed for her powerful vocals, punchy solos and patchwork sound that incorporates funk, rock and soul. Her set will feature tracks across her four solo studio albums and a bit of Bonnie Raitt, who's among her key influences. ■

–Amit Gurbaxani

Tickets for the Mahindra Blues Festival are available on bookmyshow.com

